

this distro was very up-to-date and under regular scheduled development. After getting in touch (through e-mail) with Ben Zhao, the targets and future plans of CDlinux became clear. After using CDlinux 0.6.2 for a brief period, I found that CDlinux lacked many graphical applications for everyday desktop use, though there was nothing that the command line couldn't handle.

When I asked Zhao about the missing applications, like word processors and image editors, he made it very clear what CDlinux was about and what its aims were:

"It's a pity that a word processing application is not included in the official release. But OpenOffice is too big, KOffice has too many dependencies, and the smaller ones are just not stable enough. Try to open a complex .doc, and you'll get a lot of crashes. And the i18n support is far from usable. AbiWord, Gnumeric, and the GIMP are already in the repository, along with many other applications like aMule, ClamAV (an anti-virus), Mplayer, Transmission, Wine, etc. We'll find a way to make them available with the next release. There are still some other packages with licensing problems, like Mplayer codecs (for various audio/video formats), libdvdcss (to play encrypted DVDs), Skype, Flash plugins, firmware for various hardware, and some 'Wined' Windows applications. Regarding those packages, I don't want to ship them with the official CDlinux, because we want CDlinux to be clean! Maybe in the future, we'll help to create a community release that contains these packages. Many GUI tools for CD/DVD burning, wireless networking, installation, saving settings, etc. are planned for the 0.7 release."

The focus of CDlinux is to be a good administrative tool, with only stable, necessary and free applications and excellent i18n support.

While the community edition was always on the radar, it finally got launched on October 20, 2008, featuring a lot of proprietary codecs, and a lot more applications. Today, CDlinux has three parallel editions:

Mini: Command line only, and uses Busybox with a lot of command line tools.

Standard: A superset of Mini, featuring Xfce, and a bare minimum set of applications. This only contains free software.

Community: Made from the standard edition by adding more graphical applications, this edition is more appropriate for the everyday home user. It also contains many non-free components.

I used CDlinux on an AMD Athlon64 X2 4400+ processor with a RS690G chipset, 2 GB RAM; the Intel Pentium D with ATI Radeon 200x integrated graphics and 512 MB RAM, and two more Intel systems (one Core and another Pentium MMX 200 MHz).

Let's briefly look at the various editions. We will be working with version 0.9.3. The latest 0.9.4 release is a bugfix maintenance edition and the site encourages users to update to it.

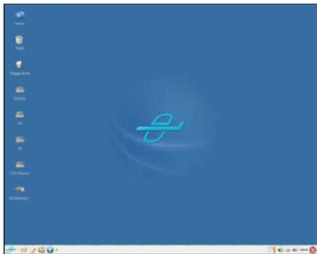


Figure 1: CDlinux desktop

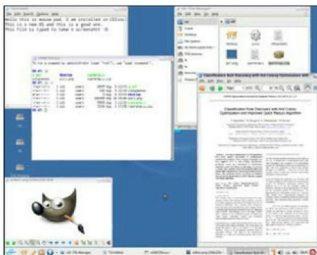


Figure 2: A snippet of available applications

The standard edition

This edition is an official release of CDlinux and contains a patched version of the Xfce 4.6.1 desktop environment, a patched Linux-2.6.30.5, with Firefox 3.5.2, Pidgin 2.6.1, Slyphed (a mail client), ePdfViewer and GpicView (an image viewer). The older 0.6.2 release (standard) featured Xine with free codecs, which went missing from the 0.9.2 release. The 0.9.2 release contained TestDisk, which made it a better rescue tool and a new CDlinux HDD and USB installer.

To begin with, download the image of the latest CDlinux, burn it on a CD(RW) and get started. Enter the CD into the CD drive after you make sure that the system boots using the CD drive. Then select the language to boot CDlinux from the bootloader menu and press *Enter*. You will see the CDlinux logo in the boot splash screen for a few seconds. This was not present in the previous stable release (0.6.2), which used a text prompt. After this, the desktop loads smoothly. It auto-detected my default 1280 x 1024 desktop resolution